

A sociologist is interested in investigating leukemia diagnoses in children. Which of the following research topics is most consistent with the sociological paradigm of symbolic interactionism? A study investigating how:

- ☐ A. socioeconomic status is related to leukemia treatment outcomes in children. [4%]
- ☐ B. the rights and obligations of the sick role apply to children diagnosed with leukemia. [11%]
- ☐ C. stereotypes about women and girls impact social support for girls diagnosed with leukemia. [9%]
- ☒ D. a child's leukemia diagnosis impacts interpersonal interactions and roles within families. [74%]

Correct

73% answered correctly

Explanation:

Major theoretical approaches to sociology			
Theory	Description	Perspective	Theorists
Functionalism	- Society = an organism - Each part of society works to maintain dynamic equilibrium (homeostasis)	Macro	Émile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons
Conflict	- Society = struggle for limited resources - Inequality based on social class	Macro	Karl Marx, Max Weber
Social constructionism	- Social actors define what is real - Knowledge about world based on interactions	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)
Symbolic interactionism	- Meaning & value attached to symbols - Individual interactions based on these symbols	Micro	Charles Cooley, George Herbert Mead
Rational choice/social exchange	Individual behaviors & interactions attempt to maximize personal gain & minimize personal cost	Micro	(Not critical for exam)
Feminist	Examines gender inequality in society	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)

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Symbolic interactionism is a microsociological perspective concerned with the **interpersonal interactions** through which people develop **subjective meanings** shaping social **reality**. Subjective meanings differ by context and culture (eg, handshaking in the United States vs bowing in Japan) and can change over time.

In symbolic interactionism, the **definition of the situation** describes how **shared expectations** for **behavior** help people understand the **roles** of

everyone involved in an interaction. For example, patients expect doctors to behave professionally and maintain confidentiality.

The research topic most consistent with symbolic interactionism is the study investigating how a child's leukemia diagnosis impacts families' *interpersonal interactions* (eg, parents spend more time with a child diagnosed with leukemia and less time with healthy siblings) and *roles* (eg, a parent quits work to become the child's caretaker).

(Choice A) Conflict theory is a macro-level approach focusing on how inequalities between social classes cause conflict. An examination of socioeconomic status and leukemia treatment outcomes is a macro-level approach that better aligns with a *conflict* (not symbolic interactionist) perspective.

(Choice B) Structural functionalism, a macro-level approach emphasizing how social structures maintain equilibrium in society, suggests that illness is a form of socially sanctioned deviance (ie, sick role theory). A study focusing on the sick role reflects a *functionalist* (not symbolic interactionist) approach.

(Choice C) Feminist theory focuses on sex/gender inequality in society from a macro- and micro-perspective. Studying the impact of stereotypes about sex differences on social support for girls with leukemia is an approach that better aligns with a *feminist* (not symbolic interactionist) perspective.

Educational objective:

Symbolic interactionism is a microsociological perspective that suggests that people develop subjective meanings for things (eg, objects, behaviors) through social interaction. The definition of the situation allows people to understand the roles of everyone involved in a social encounter so that each person acts accordingly.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:401697
System:
Identity and Social Interaction

A successful business owner has a motor vehicle collision, leaving him paralyzed and in a wheelchair. He perceives that his colleagues and clients begin to treat him as though he is less capable. He starts to doubt his ability to successfully run his business. This reaction is best explained by which of the following?

- ☐ A. Strain theory [5%]
- ✓ ☒ B. Looking-glass self [92%]
- ☐ C. Dramaturgical approach [1%]
- ☐ D. Psychosexual theory of development

Correct

91% answered correctly

Explanation:



The **looking-glass self** is a symbolic interactionist concept that suggests that our **interpretation** of how we are **perceived** by others **impacts** our **self-concept** (beliefs about ourselves). In addition, our interpretation of what others think about us is more important than what they *actually* think. For example, a coach may provide feedback to the most talented player, but that player may interpret (and then internalize) this as an indication that the coach doesn't think she is very good.

The concept of the looking-glass self best explains the business owner's shift in self-concept (ie, doubting his ability to run his business) as a result of his interpretation of the perceptions of others after his accident.

(Choice A) Strain theory suggests that when individuals are unable to attain socially acceptable goals (eg, having a nice car) through legitimate means (eg, a job), the resulting strain may lead to deviant behavior (eg, stealing). Strain theory does not address how self-concept is shaped by the interpretations of others' perceptions.

(Choice C) The dramaturgical approach explains behavior using a theater metaphor: How we behave in front of others (the "audience") is a "performance" meant to manage their impression of us. The dramaturgical approach does not address an individual's *interpretation* and *internalization* of others' perceptions.

(Choice D) Psychosexual theory of development states that personality develops through five psychosexual stages that begin in childhood; conflict in any of these stages can lead to psychological issues (eg, anxiety) in adulthood. The impact of interpreting others' perceptions on self-concept is not explored in this theory.

Educational objective:

The concept of the looking-glass self is part of the symbolic interactionism perspective and states

that an individual's self-concept is shaped by that person's interpretation of others' perceptions, regardless of the accuracy of those interpretations.

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